Isometry Pursuit: Convex Recovery of Orthonormal Column Submatrices

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Abstract

Isometry pursuit is a convex algorithm for identifying orthonormal column-submatrices of wide matrices.s It consists of a vector normalization followed by multitask basis pursuit. Applied to Jacobians of putative coordinate functions, it helps identity locally isometric embeddings from within interpretable dictionaries. We provide theoretical and experimental results justifying this method, including a proof with realistic assumptions that such isometric submatrices, should they exist, are contained within the obtained support. For problems involving coordinate selection and diversification, it offers a synergistic alternative to greedy and brute force search.

1 Introduction

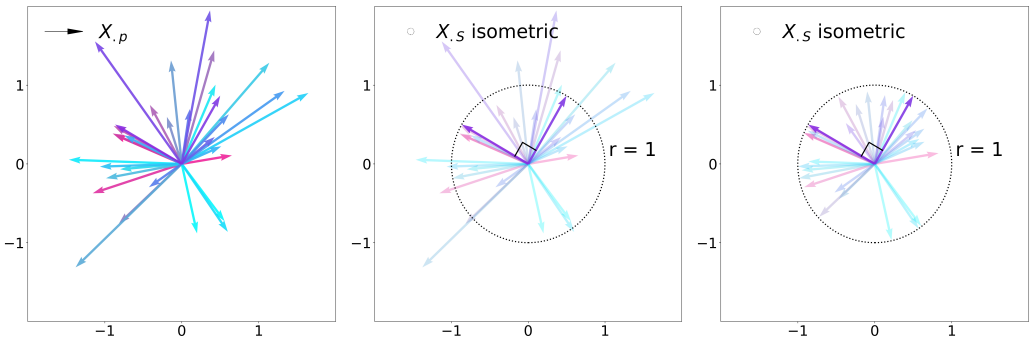
Many real-world problems may be abstracted as selecting a subset of the columns of a matrix representing stochastic observations or analytically exact data. This paper focuses on a simple such problem. Given a rank D matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times P}$ with $P > D$, select a square submatrix $X_{.S}$ where subset $S \subset [P]$ satisfies $|S| = D$ that is as isometric as possible.

This problem arises in feature learning because while the coordinate functions of a given feature space may have no intrinsic meaning, it is often possible to generate a dictionary of interpretable features for consideration as potential parametrizing coordinates. When this is the case, selection of candidate interpretable features as coordinates can take the above form. Isometric embeddings - data mappings that compress high-dimensional distributions into low dimensions while preserving distances and angles on the data surface - have differentials that are isometric matrices. Thus, selecting isometric embeddings from without dictionaries of putative coordinates can be cast as a linear isometric submatrix coordinate selection problem. Identification of such coordinates generally aids mechanistic understanding, generative control, and statistical efficiency.

This paper takes an optimization perspective on the problem of selecting isometric submatrices. The background develops the the problem from the perspective of non-linear embeddings. However, the focus switches to a purely linear algebraic perspective in the remainder of the paper.

The main contribution of this paper is to show that an adapted version of the multitask basis pursuit feature learning algorithm in Koelle et al. (2024) is a convex alternative isometry selection algorithm. This enables identification of low-dimensional coordinates within a Jacobian that preserve the original geometry of the data manifold under mapping given by the flow lines This algorithm - IsometryPursuit - is multitask basis pursuit applied to an appropriately normalized X selects orthonormal submatrices. Given vectors in $\mathbb{R}^D$, the normalization log-symmetrizes length and favors those closer to unit length, while basis pursuit favors those which are orthogonal. Our theoretical results formalize this intuition, and show the usefulness of IsometryPursuit as a trimming procedure prior to brute force search for diversification and interpretable coordinate selection. It is an alternative to greedy coordinate selection approaches such as those in Cai and Wang (2011); Chen and Meila (2019); Kohli et al. (2021); Jones et al. (2007).

[1]Work conducted outside of Amazon.



(a) Raw data (b) Isometric subset (c) Normalization step

Figure 1: 1a Raw data X represented as column-vectors. 1b An isometric subset - the identification of which is our objective. 1c The vectors after normalization so that vectors of length 1 maintain longest length.

2 Background

Selecting a subset of columns from a matrix that is as orthonormal as possible is a rather generic linear algebra problem. We therefore motivate the problem from the perspective of non-linear embeddings.

2.1 Problem

Our goal is, given a matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times P}$, to select a subset $S \subset [P]$ with $|S| = D$ such that $X_{\cdot S}$ is as orthonormal as possible in a computationally efficient way. To this end, we define a ground truth loss function that measures orthonormalness, and then introduce a surrogate loss function that convexifies the problem so that it may be efficiently solved. Figure 1a and 1b provide a visual depiction of this problem when $D = 2$ and $P = 30$.

2.2 Isometry

Isometries are a classical object in numerical linear algebra and geometry. The mathematical construct central to our estimation problem is the isometric linear map.

Definition 1 *A matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times P}$ is an **isometry** or, equivalently, **unitary** if*

$$XX^T = I_D. \tag{1}$$

Note that necessarily, $P \geq D$.

The analogous object for smooth nonlinear maps is defined through the differential.

Definition 2 *The **differential** of a smooth map $\phi : \mathcal{M} \to \mathcal{N}$ between D dimensional manifolds $\mathcal{M} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^B$ and $\mathcal{N} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^P$ is a map in tangent bases $x_1 \dots x_D$ of $T_\xi\mathcal{M}$ and $y_1 \dots y_D$ of $T_{\phi(\xi)}\mathcal{N}$ consisting of entries*

$$D\phi(\xi) = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial\phi_1}{\partial x_1}(\xi) & \dots & \frac{\partial\phi_1}{\partial x_D}(\xi) \\ \vdots & & \vdots \\ \frac{\partial\phi_D}{\partial x_1}(\xi) & \dots & \frac{\partial\phi_D}{\partial x_D}(\xi) \end{bmatrix}. \tag{2}$$

Definition 3 *A map ϕ between D dimensional submanifolds with inherited Euclidean metric $\mathcal{M} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^B$ and $\mathcal{N} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^P$ is an **isometry at a point** $\xi \in \mathcal{M}$ if*

$$D\phi(\xi)^T D\phi(\xi) = I_D. \tag{3}$$

That is, ϕ is an isometry at ξ if $D\phi(\xi)$ is orthonormal.

Reference	Loss function	Linearized?	S
Chen and Meila (2019)		Yes	
Kohli et al. (2021)	$\ell_{distortion} = \sup_{\xi',\xi'' \in \mathcal{N}(\xi)} \frac{\|f_{.S}(\xi') - f_{.S}(\xi'')\|_2}{d(\xi',\xi'')} \inf_{\xi',\xi'' \in \mathcal{N}(\xi)} \frac{d(\xi',\xi'')}{\|f_{.S}(\xi') - f_{.S}(\xi)\|_2}$	No	
Koelle et al. (2024)	$\ell_{TSLASSO}$	Yes	
Koelle (2022)	$\ell_{TS,BP}$	Yes	

Table 1: Dictionary-based manifold learning losses.

Definition 4 *A map ϕ between D dimensional submanifolds with inherited Euclidean metric $\mathcal{M} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^B$ and $\mathcal{N} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^P$ is **conformal at a point** $\xi \in \mathcal{M}$ if there exists a scalar $\lambda(\xi) > 0$ such that*

$$D\phi(\xi)^T D\phi(\xi) = \lambda(\xi) I_D. \tag{4}$$

That is, ϕ is conformal at ξ if its differential preserves angles but may rescale lengths.

Definition 1 has several related formulations.

Proposition 1 *The singular values $\sigma_1(X) \dots \sigma_D(X)$ are equal to 1 if and only if X is an isometry.*

Proposition 2 *If $P = D$, the component vectors $X_{.1} \dots X_{.D} \in \mathbb{R}^D$ form an isometry if and only if, for all $d_1, d_2 \in [D]$, $\langle X_{.d_1}, X_{.d_2} \rangle = \begin{cases} 1 & d_1 = d_2 \\ 0 & d_1 \neq d_2 \end{cases}$.*

Distance-preserving maps between Riemannian manifolds are smooth isometries

Proposition 3 *Let $\mathcal{M}$ and $\mathcal{N}$ be connected Riemannian manifolds with Riemannian distances $d_{\mathcal{M}}$ and $d_{\mathcal{N}}$. A map $\phi : \mathcal{M} \to \mathcal{N}$ preserves distances,*

$$d_{\mathcal{N}}(\phi(\xi_1), \phi(\xi_2)) = d_{\mathcal{M}}(\xi_1, \xi_2), \tag{5}$$

if and only if ϕ is smooth and is an isometry at every point (Lee, 2018, Problem 6-7).

This motivates embedding algorithms such as Local Tangent Space Alignment (Zhang and Zha, 2004), Multidimensional Scaling (Chen and Buja, 2009), and Isomap (Tenenbaum et al., 2000) to non-parametrically estimate embeddings that are as close to isometric as possible.

2.3 Coordinate selection

More recently, methods for selecting D coordinates from a dictionary $f_{1:P}$ of candidate features have emerged (Kohli et al., 2021; Koelle et al., 2022; **?**). One motivation for this approach to from a dictionary of candidate features that have been pre-identified as interpretable (Koelle et al., 2024). In contrast, Kohli et al. (2021) seeks selection of a subset of coordinates that are as conformal as possible, in a manner that we will explain in the next section. In Kohli et al. (2021), this loss function is computer for each individual data point, while in Koelle et al. (2022); **?**, the loss function is computed over the entire dataset.

The dictionary-based coordinate search problem best subset selection problem is

$$\arg \min_{S \in \binom{[P]}{D}} \ell(f_{.S}) \tag{6}$$

where ℓ is some loss function that measures isometricness of a selected functional subset $f_{.S}$.

2.4 Linearized coordinate selection

In contrast, the linearized version of this problem is

$$\arg \min_{S \in \binom{[P]}{D}} \ell(Df_{.S}(\xi)) \tag{7}$$

where ℓ is now a loss function that measures the orthonormalness of a matrix. Koelle et al. (2024) computes $Df_{.S}(\xi)$ via automatic differentiation.

Loss Function	Definition	Unique min.	Min. at isometry	Prefers unit-length	Prefers orthogonal
Distortion[Kohli et al. (2021)]	$\sigma_{\max}(X)/\sigma_{\min}(X) - 1$	No	Yes	No	Yes
Generic spectral loss	$\ell(X) = \sum_{d=1}^{D} g(\sigma_d(X))$	Depends on g	Depends on g	Depends on g	Depends on g
Normalized log-det volume	$-\sum_{d=1}^{D} \log \sigma_d \left(n_q^{\times P}(X)\right)$	No	No	Yes	No
Frob. pseudoinverse	$\|n_q^{\times P}(X)^\dagger\|_F - \sqrt{D}$	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
IsometryPursuit	$\|n_q^{\times P}(X)^\dagger\|_{1,2} - D$	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Table 2: Matrix loss functions evaluated for isometry pursuit. We evaluate four key properties: whether the loss has a unique minimum, whether it is minimized specifically at orthonormal matrices (isometries), whether it prefers unit-length vectors over scaled versions, and whether it prefers orthogonal (orthonormal) structure.

2.5 Isometry losses

Loss functions for isometry vary on many axes. For example, functions may be measured at a single point (Kohli et al., 2021) or over an entire dataset (Koelle et al., 2022; 2024; Chen and Meila, 2019). The loss function may make use of either linearized or non-linearized objectives. Linearized objectives can be computed via automatic differentiation, or estimated. Isometry may be relaxed as optimization target to the weaker notion of conformalness or embedding.

In this paper, we will focus the optimizamizability of the loss function itself and other intuitive properties for linearized single point isometry losses. However, we will draw motivation and methods from existing methods. These methods as applied in the dictionary-based manifold learning literature are summarized in Table 1.

Proposition 4 *The distortion loss function of f_S is equal to the condition number (Golub and Wilkinson; Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004) $\frac{\sigma_1(X)}{\sigma_D(X)}$ of $Df_{\cdot S}(\xi)$ as $\mathcal{N}(\xi) \to \{\xi\}$.*

Proposition 5 *This is minimized by conformal maps.*

From the linear algebra literature, a class of functions more suitable for measuring isometry are S-divergences (Sra, 2011). S-divergences define a distance $D(P, P')$ on positive definite matrices P, P' given by

$$D(P, P') = (\log\det(\frac{P+P'}{2}) - \frac{1}{2}\log\det(PP'))^{\frac{1}{2}}. \tag{8}$$

Applied to the positive definite matrices X^TX and I_D, the S-divergence is a log singular value penalty.

Proposition 6 *If X^TX is positive definite, then*

$$D(X^TX, I_D)^2 = \sum_{d=1}^{D} \log \frac{\sigma_d(X) + \sigma_d(X)^{-1}}{2}. \tag{9}$$

By Proposition 1, this function is uniquely minimized by isometric matrices.

2.6 Sparse convex coordinate selection

Equipped with function $\ell(X)$ such as $D(X, I_D)$ that is minimized by an isometry, brute force algorithms consider all possible solutions in the sense of Proposition **??**. These algorithms are conceptually simple, but have the often prohibitive time complexity $O(C_\ell P^D)$ where C_ℓ is the cost of evaluating ℓ. Greedy algorithms consist of iteratively adding one element at a time to S. This algorithms have time complexity $O(C_\ell PD)$ and so are computationally more efficient than brute force algorithms, but can get stuck in local minima. Formal definitions are given in Section 6.1.

Sometimes, it is possible to introduce an objective which convexifies problems of the above form (Liberti, 2004; Abdi, 2013; Zhou and Low, 2021).

$$\arg\min f(\beta) : Y = X\beta \tag{10}$$

to the overcomplete regression problem $Y = X\beta$ are a classic example (Scott Shaobing Chen and David L. Donoho and Michael A. Saunders, 2001). When $f(\beta) = \|\beta\|_0$, this problem is non-convex, and is thus suitable for greedy or brute algorithms, but when $f(\beta) = \|\beta\|_1$, the problem is convex, and may be solved efficiently via interior-point methods. When the equality constraint is relaxed, Lagrangian duality may be used to reformulate as a so-called Lasso problem, which leads to an even richer set of optimization algorithms (Hastie et al., 2016).

3 Method

The contributions of this paper is that we introduce an ℓ uniquely minimized by isometries that is

- convex in its parameters
- induces sparsity
- is more appropriate than S-divergence when an isometric submatrix is not present in that it always favors vectors of unit length

This ℓ is a multitask inspired by the group basis pursuit (Koelle et al., 2022; Szeghy et al., 2022) which we call differently since grouping is dependent only on the structure of matrix-valued response variable I_D. We apply the multitask basis pursuit paradigm used to select independent dictionary elements in Koelle et al. (2022; 2024) to the more specific problem of selecting pointwise isometries from a dictionary. We first define a ground truth objective computable via brute and greedy algorithms that is uniquely minimized by orthonormal matrices. We then define the combination of normalization and multitask basis pursuit that approximates this ground truth loss function. We finally give a brute post-processing method for ensuring that the solution is D sparse, and provide a theoretical result that the two stage approach will always result in recovery of an isometric solution from the dictionary, should one exist.

3.1 Ground truth and ground truther

(11)

(12)

$\ell_S(X) = D(X^T X, I_D)$ is minimized uniquely by orthonormal matrices and invariant under rotation. However, it is plainly not the only function of X satisfying these properties. Consider that function

$$\ell : \mathbb{R}^{D\times P} \to \mathbb{R}^+ \tag{13}$$

$$X \mapsto \sum_{d=1}^{D} g(\sigma_d(X)) \tag{14}$$

where

$$g : \mathbb{R}^+ \to \mathbb{R}^+ \tag{15}$$

$$t \mapsto \log \frac{t + t^{-1}}{2}. \tag{16}$$

Clearly, any g uniquely minimized at 1 will provide a suitable rescaling of singular values. However, there are some nice properties we may also want. Monotonicity away from 1. $g(t) = t(t^{-1})$. See for example Cichocki et al. (2014) for a variety of log-polynomial singular value divergences on positive definite matrices satisfying these property. We provide a heuristic answer to the first question and a more rigorous to the second. Intuitively, the problem with singular values seems to be that they can blow up when X is rank deficient and so aren't very good for partially correct answers. On the other hand, the log-polynomial loss grows quite slowly with error and so is overly forgiving.

The deep issue is more subtle. Essentially, we want a loss that grows the further from isometry we are. Among the conditions for satisfying this are that given a set of angles between vectors we want the loss to be less when the vectors are length 1. This is an issue for singular-value based losses, since two colinear vectors of length 1 will increase a singular value to $\sqrt{2}$. In this way, as one of the vectors is shortened, the singular value passes through 1. What of the other singular values? It was quite small, and it now has gotten a little bit smaller, but not commesurately with the decrease in loss from the top singular value.

Put mathematically, we want

$$\frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \|x_{.d}\|_2} \begin{cases} > 0 \ : \ \|x_{.d}\|_2 > 1 \\ = 0 \ : \ \|x_{.d}\|_2 = 1 \\ < 0 \ : \ \|x_{.d}\|_2 < 1 \end{cases} \tag{17}$$

for all X. What this property says is that, as a column-set becomes more normal, the loss is lower. This property is plainly of interest for isometry selection.

What is also of interest is the following log-symmetry property.

Unfortunately, we show the following proposition.

Proposition 7 *There does not exist a g such that $\ell = \sum_{d=1}^{D} g(\sigma_d(X))$ such that ℓ satisfies Property and*

Property 1

$$g(t) = g(1/t) \tag{18}$$

A suitable counterexample is shown in Section 6.2.2. The issue basically is that colinear vectors punish singular value based losses by pushing larger singular values away from 1. The issue can also be seen visually in Figure **??**, where the level sets of the log det losses are not tangent to length at $r = 1$, meaning that given an angle loss can actually be decreased by shrinking

Although starting from singular values is bad in the sense of Proposition , other losses do satisfy this property. These losses arise from the obvious intuition that we can shrink vectors away from length 1 in a manner similar to how we selected g. Then, we can apply some loss function to the rescaled matrix that satisfies Property 7.

In fact, two fundamentally different loss functions first come under consideration. The determinant of the rescaled matrix will be maximized at orthonormality. Determinant is monotonic with product of singular values. So now basically we can do something with product of the singular values rather than their log sum.

Why is product bad?

Sum of singular values is the trace. So will the sum of its squared singular values. On the other hand we can apply a method-of-frames penalty. Also note that trace of A transpose A is in fact the nuclear norm.

These divergences raise the question of what is the most reasonable form of g, and whether starting with singular values is a good way to define an isometry loss.

$$g : \mathbb{R}^+ \to \mathbb{R}^+ \tag{19}$$

$$t \mapsto \frac{e^t + e^{t^{-1}}}{2e}. \tag{20}$$

By Proposition 1, we can see that ℓ is uniquely maximized by orthonormal matrices. Moreover, g is convex, and $\ell(X^{-1}) = \ell(X)$ when X is invertible. Figure 2 gives graphs of candidate losses when $D = 1$ and $D = 2$. Figure 3 gives the analogous two-parameter view for $D = 3$ equicorrelated matrices.

Our ground truth objective is therefore the best subset selection problem

$$\arg \min_{S \in \binom{[P]}{d}} \ell(X_{.S}). \tag{21}$$

Regardless of the convexity of ℓ, brute combinatorial search over $[P]$ is inherently non-convex. This motivates our alternative formulation.

3.2 Normalization

Since basis pursuit methods tend to select longer vectors, selection of orthonormal submatrices requires normalization such that both long and short candidate basis vectors are penalized in the subsequent regression. We introduce the following definition.

Definition 5 (Symmetric normalization) *A function $q : \mathbb{R}^D \to \mathbb{R}^+$ is a symmetric normalization if*

$$\arg\max_{v\in\mathbb{R}^D} \; q(v) = \{v : \|v\|_2 = 1\} \tag{22}$$

$$q(v) = q(\frac{v}{\|v\|_2^2}) \tag{23}$$

$$q(v_1) = q(v_2) \; \forall \; v_1, v_2 \in \mathbb{R}^D : \|v_1\|_2 = \|v_2\|_2. \tag{24}$$

We use such functions to normalize column-vector length in such a way that vectors of length 1 prior to normalization have longest length after normalization and vectors are shrunk proportionately to their deviation from 1. That is, we normalize vectors by

$$n : \mathbb{R}^D \to \mathbb{R}^D \tag{25}$$

$$v \mapsto q(v)\frac{v}{\|v\|_2} \tag{26}$$

and matrices by

$$w : \mathbb{R}^{D\times P} \to \mathbb{R}^{D\times P} \tag{27}$$

$$X_{.p} \mapsto n(X_{.p}) \; \forall \; p \in [P]. \tag{28}$$

We choose q as follows.

$$q : \mathbb{R}^D \to \mathbb{R}^+ \tag{29}$$

$$v \mapsto \frac{2e}{e^{\|v\|_2} + e^{\|v\|_2^{-1}}}. \tag{30}$$

Besides satisfying the conditions in Definition 5, this normalization has some additional nice properties. First, q is convex. Second, it grows asymptotically log-linearly. Third, while $\exp(-|\log t|) = \exp(-\max(t, 1/t))$ is a seemingly natural choice for normalization, it is non smooth, and the LogSumExp (Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004) replacement of $\max(t, 1/t)$ with $\log(\exp(t)+\exp(1/t))$ simplifies to 30 upon exponentiation. This normalization provides good numerical properties for avoiding issues arising close to 0 and ∞. We plot the effect of this normalization on our example data in Figure 1c.

3.3 Isometry pursuit

Isometry pursuit is the application of multitask basis pursuit to the normalized design matrix $w(X)$ to identify submatrices of X that are as orthonormal as possible. Define the multitask basis pursuit penalty

$$\|\cdot\|_{1,2} : \mathbb{R}^{P\times D} \to \mathbb{R}^+ \tag{31}$$

$$\beta \mapsto \sum_{p=1}^{P} \|\beta_{p.}\|_2. \tag{32}$$

Given a matrix $Y \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times D}$, the multitask basis pursuit solutions are

$$\widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(X, Y) := \arg\min_{\beta\in\mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta\|_{1,2} \; : \; Y = X\beta. \tag{33}$$

The multitask basis pursuit solution is often not unique. See Schneider and Tardivel (2022) for more details on uniqueness of basis pursuit solutions, for which the uniqueness condition is less strict than in the multitask case. We therefore define

$$\widehat{\beta}^{\ell_2}_{MLP}(X,Y) := \arg\min \|\beta\|_F : \beta \in \beta_{MBP}(X,Y). \tag{34}$$

By the strong convexity of the ℓ_2 norm, $\widehat{\beta}^{\ell_2}_{MLP}(X,Y)$ is well defined.

This implicit regularization assumption is reasonable. For example, in Tibshirani (2012a) the implicit selection of the minimum ℓ_2 norm solution among the lasso solutions was proven for the Least Angle Regression Selection (LARS) algorithm for solving the lasso, while Mishkin and Pilanci (2022a) assumes that the group lasso solution is in fact min-norm prior to subsequent theoretical analyses. Empirically, the Splitting Conic Solver type method (which is itself a variant of the Alternating Direction Method of Multilpliers) (O'Donoghue et al., 2013) stably estimates the min-norm solution when initialized at 0, but besides a brief exploration in Section **??** we leave theoretical and experimental proof of this feature of the feature our optimization approach for future work, and instead make the ability of our optimizer to obtain the min-norm solution an assumption of our eventual proposition.

Isometry pursuit is then given by

$$\widehat{\beta}(X) := \widehat{\beta}^{\ell_2}_{MBP}(w(X), I_D) \tag{35}$$

where I_D is the D dimensional identity matrix and recovered functions are the indices of the dictionary elements with non-zero coefficients. That is, they are given by $S(\beta)$ where

$$S : \mathbb{R}^{P\times D} \to \binom{[P]}{D} \tag{36}$$

$$\beta \mapsto \{p \in [P] : \|\beta_{p\cdot}\| > 0\}. \tag{37}$$

IsometryPursuit(Matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times P}$)

1: Normalize $X' = w(X)$
2: Optimize $\widehat{\beta} = \widehat{\beta}^{\ell_2}_{MBP}(X', I_D)$
3: **Output** $\widehat{S} = S(\widehat{\beta})$

3.4 Theory

The intuition behind our application of multitask basis pursuit is that submatrices consisting of vectors which are closer to 1 in length and more orthogonal will have smaller loss. A key theoretical assertion is that IsometryPursuit is invariant to choice of basis for X.

Proposition 8 *Let $U \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times D}$ be orthonormal. Then $S(\widehat{\beta}(UX)) = S(\widehat{\beta}(X))$.*

This proposition establishes the basis-independence of Isometry Pursuit and that we may replace I_D in the constraint by any orthonormal $D \times D$ matrix. It is also essential for showing the following main theoretical result.

When a rank D orthonormal column-submatrix $X_{\cdot S}$ exists, the output of Program 35 will contain S.

Proposition 9 *Let $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times P}$ have a rank D orthonormal column submatrix $X_{\cdot S}$. Then $S \subseteq \widehat{\beta}(X)$.*

Proofs of these propositions are given in Section 6.2, with corresponding experimental results in Section 4. The proof mostly relies on the KKT conditions (Hastie et al., 2015) being used to verify that an isometric subset yields a corresponding basis pursuit solution for an appropriate normalized matrix. This is a formalization of our intuition that longer and more orthogonal vectors will minimize loss. We then apply a simple argument to show that the ℓ_2 minimizing solution is the least sparse solution, which means that it contains the isometry solution, should it exist.

3.5 Two-stage isometry pursuit

Proposition 9 suggests the following algorithm, which first uses the convex IsometryPursuit algorithm to prune the P candidate features and then applies brute search upon the reduced feature set. The proposition says that this approach is guaranteed to select an isometric submatrix should one exist. The two-stage approach is standard in the Lasso literature (Meinshausen, 2007; Hesterberg et al., 2008; Koelle et al., 2022), and Proposition 9 justifies it in our application. This method forms our practical isometry estimator, the core advantage of which over purely brute search is a substantially improved computational complexity.

TwoStageIsometryPursuit(Matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D \times P}$)

1: $\widehat{S}_{IP} = \text{IsometryPursuit}(X)$
2: $\widehat{S} = \text{BruteSearch}(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_{IP}}, \ell)$
3: **Output** $\widehat{S}$

3.6 Non-uniqueness

The isometric solution is optimum among cardinality D solutions.

Proposition 10 $\ell(X_S) = D, |S| = D \Leftrightarrow X_S X_S^T = I_D$

However, there exist Isometry Pursuit solutions of minimum norm that are not isometries. For example, *Mercedes-Benz frame* matrix X achieves minimium norm.

Example 1 *Let* $D = 2, P = 3$. *Let* $X_S = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & -\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \\ 1 & -\frac{1}{2} & -\frac{1}{2} \end{bmatrix}, \beta = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & \frac{2}{3} \\ \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}} & -\frac{1}{3} \\ -\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}} & -\frac{1}{3} \end{bmatrix}$ *Then* $X\beta = I_D$ *and* $\|\beta\|_{1,2} = \frac{2}{3} + \frac{2}{3} + \frac{2}{3} = 2 = D$. *Since the identity matrix is a solution regardless of* X_{-S}, *this is a non-isometric minimum loss solution.*

The upshot of this example is that IsometryPursuit can select solutions that are relatively non-isometric. The Mercedes-Benz frame is an example of a tight frame - a frame whose non-zero singular values are equal. While there are non-tight frames that have minimizing solutions, we do not here resolve whether there exist tight frames with unit norm columns that have minimum norm solutions.

3.7 Computation complexity

IsometryPursuit is more computationally efficient than BruteSearch search for the minimizer of ℓ. Interestingly, their asymptotic per-iteration complexities are the same.

Proposition 11 *The computational complexity* C_ℓ *of 13 is* $O(D^2 P)$.

The above proposition follows immediately from the computational complexity of singular value decomposition (Liang et al., 2016). The per-iteration complexity of IsometryPursuit is also limited by the computational complexity of singular value decomposition, albeit in the more intricate manner described in Section 6.2.6.

Proposition 12 *The computational complexity of each step of Isometry Pursuit is* $O(D^2 P)$.

The difference therefore lies in the relation of the number of iterations required to achieve a given error tolerance with IsometryPursuit and BruteSearch. To optimize, we use the SCS interior point solver (O'Donoghue et al., 2016) from CVXPY (Diamond and Boyd, 2016; Agrawal et al., 2018), which is able to push sparse values arbitrarily close to 0 (CVXPY Developers). SCS (aka ADMM) has asymptotic (in error) accuracy $\epsilon < O(\frac{1}{\mathcal{S}})$, where $\mathcal{S}$ is the number of iterations (He and Yuan, 2012). This means that the number of iterations

Name	D	P	R	$\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G})$	$\lvert\widehat{S}\rvert$	$\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}})$	$\widehat{P}(\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G}) > \ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}}))$	$\widehat{P}(\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G}) = \ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}}))$	$\widehat{P}(\bar{\ell}_1(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G}) > \bar{\ell}_1(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}}))$
Iris	4	75	25	14 ± 7.3	6.7 ± 1	6.9 ± 1.4	0.96	0	2.4e-05
Wine	6	89	25	7.7 ± 0.33	13 ± 1.5	7.6 ± 0.29	0.64	0.16	6.3e-04
Ethanol	2	756	25	2.6 ± 0.3	90 ± 1.7e+02	2.5 ± 0.2	0.66	0.17	2.1e-05

Table 3: Experimental parameters and results. For Iris and Wine, probability estimates $\widehat{P}$ result from random downsampling features $[P]$ by a factor of 2 to create R replicates, while for Ethanol, replicates correspond to individual data points. Distributional probabilities $\widehat{P}(\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G}) > \ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_{TSIP}}))$ and $\widehat{P}(\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G}) = \ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_{TSIP}}))$ are empirical across replicates, while asymptotic probabilities $\widehat{P}(\bar{\ell}_1(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G}) > \bar{\ell}_1(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_{TSIP}}))$ is computed by paired two-sample T-test on $\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}})$ and $\ell(X_{\cdot \widehat{S}_G})$. For brevity, in this table $\widehat{S} := \widehat{S}_{TSIP}$.

required to achieve a given error tolerance scales inversely with the desired level of accuracy. We examine the effect of iteration number on the convergence to a sparse solution in Section 4.

4 Experiments

Say you are hosting a dinner party, and wish to select a balanced set of wines for drinking and flowers for decoration. We demonstrate TwoStageIsometryPursuit and GreedySearch on the Iris and Wine datasets (Fisher, 1988; Aeberhard and Forina, 1991; Pedregosa et al., 2011). This has an intuitive interpretation as selecting diverse elements that reflects the peculiar structure of the diversification problem. Features like *petal width* are rows in X. Thus, in diversification, $P = n$. Due to differences in scales between features, these are first standardized. For the Wine dataset, even BruteSearch on $\widehat{S}_{IP}$ is prohibitive in $D = 13$, and so we sample our inputs to $D = 6$.

Our main interpretability dataset is the Ethanol dataset from Chmiela et al. (2018); Koelle et al. (2022). For this dataset evaluate a dictionary of interpretable features - bond torsions - for their ability to parameterize the molecular configuration space. In this interpretability use case, columns denote gradients of informative features. We compute Jacoban matrices of putative parametrization functions and project them onto estimated tangent spaces (see Koelle et al. (2022) for preprocessing details). Rather than selecting between data points, we are selecting between functions which parameterize the data. Replicas are created by sampling from data points and their corresponding tangent spaces are estimated in $B = 252$. This dataset exemplifies our motivating example - the search for locally isometric embeddings.

Figure 4 and Table 3 show that the ℓ accrued by the subset $\widehat{S}_G$ estimated using GreedySearch with objective ℓ is higher than that for the subset estimated by TwoStageIsometryPursuit. This effect is statistically significant across datasets. Generally, the ground truth loss obtained by GreedySearch optimization of ℓ is higher and therefore worse than that obtained by two-stage isometry pursuit. Table 3 and Figure 5 detail intermediate support recovery cardinalities from IsometryPursuit. Isometry pursuit substantially reduced the size of the dictionary and made brute search computationally feasible. Wall-clock runtimes are given in Section 6.5.

5 Discussion

We have shown that multitask basis pursuit can help select isometric submatrices from appropriately normalized wide matrices. This approach - IsometryPursuit - is a convex alternative to greedy methods for selection of orthonormalized features from within a dictionary. Isometry pursuit can be applied to diversification and geometrically-faithful coordinate estimation. Our results exemplify these applications, but more can be done.

On the theoretical side, a critical unresolved question is the relation of the brute force and IsometryPursuit minimizers. Essentially, there are two things that can go wrong. First,

IsometryPursuit may trim insufficiently for brute force search to be computationally feasible. Second, the recovered support may not contain the true minimizer. While we have ruled out the second problem in the case where an isometric solution does exist, in practice we often see greedy recovery defeat IsometryPursuit. Characterization of support recovery here is somewhat different from existing analysis of greedy (Mallat and Zhang, 1993; 1992; Pati et al., 1993; Tropp et al., 2005) and convex (Scott Shaobing Chen and David L. Donoho and Michael A. Saunders, 2001; Tropp, 2006; Chen and Huo, 2006) basis pursuit formulations. Partly, this is because we use the ℓ_1 minimizer to distinguish between ℓ_0 optima rather than to identify them. Also, IsometryPursuit can generate non-unique solutions even when the design matrix satisfies general position, which is not true for the univariate formulation (Osborne et al., 2000; Dossal, 2012; Chrétien and Darses, 2011; Tibshirani, 2012b; Ewald and Schneider, 2017; Ali and Tibshirani, 2018; Schneider and Tardivel, 2020; Mishkin and Pilanci, 2022b; Dupuis and Vaiter, 2019; Debarre et al., 2020; Everink et al., 2024), but

The principal algorithmic variant of interest is the combination of the multitask lasso (Hastie et al., 2015) extension of our estimator with D function selection within $\mathbb{R}^B$. First, introducing a Lasso penalty may ameliorate IsometryPursuit's reliance on the second stage of coordinate selection to complete the estimation process. Using the Lasso penalty, we can smoothly move between the multitask basis pursuit solution and more sparse solutions (Mishkin and Pilanci, 2022a). Second, we often may want to select some orthonormal subset of dimension much less than D. Finally, response matrices may be extended beyond the identity.

These extensions may faciliate an interesting set of applications diversification in recommendation (Carbonell and Goldstein, 1998a; Wu et al., 2019; Lan) and retrieval (Gao et al., 2023; Pickett et al., 2024; In et al., 2024; Weiss, 2024; Vec). Maximum cosine similarity used in retrieval corresponds to the first coefficient of the Lasso regularization path (Koelle et al., 2022). Greedy algorithms predominate in diversification (Carbonell and Goldstein, 1998b; Barioni et al., 2011; Drosou and Pitoura, 2010; Qin et al., 2012; Kunaver and Požrl, 2017; Guo and Sanner, 2010; Abdool et al., 2020; Yu et al., 2016; Huang et al., 2024; Pickett et al., 2024; Cai and Wang, 2011; Zhu et al., 2020), and convex reformulations have been studied to add speed and convergence to a global minima.

Compared with Sparse PCA (d'Aspremont et al., 2007; Dey et al., 2017; Bertsimas and Kitane, 2022; Bertsimas et al., 2022), we seek a low-dimensional representation from the set of these column vectors rather than their span.

Diversification.

While other applications like diversification are possible and potentially , the embedding

Diversification may be framed an a kind of orthogonal selection problem. Cosine similarity Colbert

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6 Supplement

This section contains algorithms, proofs, and experiments in support of the main text.

6.1 Algorithms

We give definitions of the brute and greedy algorithms for the combinatorial problem studied in this paper. The brute force algorithm is computationally intractable for all but the smallest problems, but always finds the global minima.

BruteSearch(Matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D \times P}$, objective f)

1: **for** each combination $S \subseteq \{1, 2, \ldots, P\}$ with $|S| = D$ **do**
2: Evaluate $f(X_{.S})$
3: **end for**
4: **Output** the combination S^* that minimizes $f(X_{.S})$

Greedy algorithms are computationally expedient but can get stuck in local optima (Cormen et al., 2009; Russell and Norvig, 2009), even with randomized restarts (Dick et al., 2014).

GreedySearch(Matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{D \times P}$, objective f, selected set $S = \emptyset$, current size $d = 0$)

1: **if** $d = D$ **then**
2: **Return** S
3: **else**
4: **Initialize** $S_{\text{best}} = S$
5: **Initialize** $f_{\text{best}} = \infty$
6: **for** each $p \in \{1, 2, \ldots, P\} \setminus S$ **do**
7: **Evaluate** $f(X_{.(S \cup \{p\})})$
8: **if** $f(X_{.(S \cup \{p\})}) < f_{\text{best}}$ **then**
9: **Update** $S_{\text{best}} = S \cup \{p\}$
10: **Update** $f_{\text{best}} = f(\mathcal{X}_{.(S \cup \{p\})})$
11: **end if**
12: **end for**
13: **Return** GreedySearch(X, f, S_{best}, $d + 1$)
14: **end if**

6.2 Proofs

6.2.1 Proof of Proposition 6

Proof: First,

$$\frac{1}{2} \log \det(X^T X) = \frac{1}{2} \log \prod_{d=1}^{D} \sigma_d(X)^2 \tag{38}$$

$$= \log \prod_{d=1}^{D} \sigma_d(X) \tag{39}$$

$$= \sum_{d=1}^{D} \log \sigma_d(X). \tag{40}$$

Secondly, I_D and X^TX are diagonalizable in the same basis, so

$$\log\det(\frac{X^TX+I_D}{2}) = \log\prod_{d=1}^{D}\frac{\sigma_d(X)^2+1}{2} \tag{41}$$

$$= \sum_{d=1}^{D}\log\frac{\sigma_d(X)^2+1}{2}. \tag{42}$$

Then,

$$D(X^TX, I_D)^2 = \sum_{d=1}^{D}(\log\frac{\sigma_d(X)^2+1}{2} - \log\sigma_d(X)) \tag{43}$$

$$= \sum_{d=1}^{D}\log\frac{\sigma_d(X)^2+1}{2\sigma_d(X)} \tag{44}$$

$$= \sum_{d=1}^{D}\log\frac{\sigma_d(X)+\sigma_d(X)^{-1}}{2}. \tag{45}$$

□

6.2.2 Singular values of nearly colinear vectors

We now exhibit a matrix for which no g can be chosen such that a log det divergence satisfies Properties **??** and **??**. We parametrize this matrix as

$$X_\rho(r) = \begin{bmatrix} r & \rho & \rho \\ 0 & \sqrt{1-\rho^2} & \frac{\rho(1-\rho)}{\sqrt{1-\rho^2}} \\ 0 & 0 & \sqrt{\frac{(1-\rho)(1+2\rho)}{1+\rho}} \end{bmatrix} \tag{46}$$

where r is the length of the second vector and ρ controls the colinearity between vectors. We compute

$$\frac{\partial\ell(r)s}{\partial r}|_{r=1} = \sum_{d=1}^{3} g'(\sigma_d(X_\rho(r)))\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\sigma_d(X_\rho(r))\Big|_{r=1}. \tag{47}$$

We will to show that, for any log-symmetric g such that $g(t) = g(1/t)$ and any $\rho \in (-1, 1)$

$$\frac{\partial\ell(r)}{\partial r}|_{r=1} \neq 0. \tag{48}$$

First, let's compute $\sigma_d(X_\rho(r))$.

$$X_\rho(r)^TX_\rho(r) = \begin{bmatrix} r^2 & r\rho & r\rho \\ r\rho & 1 & \rho \\ r\rho & \rho & 1 \end{bmatrix}. \tag{49}$$

Recall that λ is an eigenvalue of a matrix A if there is a non-zero vector v such that $Av = \lambda v$. Equivalently,

$$\det(A - \lambda I) = 0. \tag{50}$$

In our case, this gives

$$0 = \det \begin{bmatrix} r^2-\lambda & r\rho & r\rho \\ r\rho & 1-\lambda & \rho \\ r\rho & \rho & 1-\lambda \end{bmatrix} \tag{51}$$

$$= (r^2-\lambda)\left((1-\lambda)^2-\rho^2\right) - r\rho\left(r\rho(1-\lambda) - r\rho^2\right) + r\rho\left(r\rho^2 - r\rho(1-\lambda)\right) \tag{52}$$

$$= (r^2-\lambda)\left((1-\lambda)^2-\rho^2\right) - 2r^2\rho^2(1-\lambda) + 2r^2\rho^3 \tag{53}$$

$$= (r^2-\lambda)(1-\rho-\lambda)(1+\rho-\lambda) - 2r^2\rho^2(1-\rho-\lambda) \tag{54}$$

$$= (1-\rho-\lambda)\left((r^2-\lambda)(1+\rho-\lambda) - 2r^2\rho^2\right) \tag{55}$$

$$= (1-\rho-\lambda)\left(r^2(1+\rho) - r^2\lambda - \lambda(1+\rho) + \lambda^2 - 2r^2\rho^2\right) \tag{56}$$

$$= (1-\rho-\lambda)\left(\lambda^2 - (r^2+1+\rho)\lambda + r^2(1+\rho-2\rho^2)\right). \tag{57}$$

Thus the eigenvalues of $X_\rho(r)^T X_\rho(r)$ are

$$\lambda_1(r) = 1-\rho, \tag{58}$$

$$\lambda_2(r) = \frac{r^2+1+\rho+\sqrt{(r^2+1+\rho)^2 - 4r^2(1+\rho-2\rho^2)}}{2} \tag{59}$$

$$= \frac{r^2+1+\rho+\sqrt{\left(r^2-(1+\rho)\right)^2 + 8r^2\rho^2}}{2}, \tag{60}$$

$$\lambda_3(r) = \frac{r^2+1+\rho-\sqrt{(r^2+1+\rho)^2 - 4r^2(1+\rho-2\rho^2)}}{2} \tag{61}$$

$$= \frac{r^2+1+\rho-\sqrt{\left(r^2-(1+\rho)\right)^2 + 8r^2\rho^2}}{2}. \tag{62}$$

Since singular values are the square roots of the eigenvalues of $X_\epsilon(r)^T X_\epsilon(r)$,

$$\sigma_1(X_\rho(r)) = \left[1-\rho\right]^{1/2}, \tag{63}$$

$$\sigma_2(X_\rho(r)) = \left[\frac{r^2+1+\rho+\sqrt{\left(r^2-(1+\rho)\right)^2 + 8r^2\rho^2}}{2}\right]^{1/2}, \tag{64}$$

$$\sigma_3(X_\rho(r)) = \left[\frac{r^2+1+\rho-\sqrt{\left(r^2-(1+\rho)\right)^2 + 8r^2\rho^2}}{2}\right]^{1/2}. \tag{65}$$

Differentiating the singular values gives

$$\frac{\partial\sigma_1}{\partial r} = 0, \tag{66}$$

$$\frac{\partial\sigma_2}{\partial r} = \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{r^2+1+\rho+\sqrt{(r^2-(1+\rho))^2+8r^2\rho^2}}{2}\right)^{-1/2} \tag{67}$$

$$\times \frac{2r + \frac{1}{2}\left(\left((r^2-(1+\rho))^2+8r^2\rho^2\right)^{-1/2}\left(2(r^2-(1+\rho))(2r)+16r\rho^2\right)\right)}{2}, \tag{68}$$

$$\frac{\partial\sigma_3}{\partial r} = \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{r^2+1+\rho-\sqrt{(r^2-(1+\rho))^2+8r^2\rho^2}}{2}\right)^{-1/2} \tag{69}$$

$$\times \frac{2r - \frac{1}{2}\left(\left((r^2-(1+\rho))^2+8r^2\rho^2\right)^{-1/2}\left(2(r^2-(1+\rho))(2r)+16r\rho^2\right)\right)}{2}. \tag{70}$$

Then

$$\sigma_1(X_\rho(1)) = (1-\rho)^{1/2}, \tag{71}$$

$$\sigma_2(X_\rho(1)) = (1+2\rho)^{1/2}, \tag{72}$$

$$\sigma_3(X_\rho(1)) = (1-\rho)^{1/2}, \tag{73}$$

$$\left.\frac{\partial \sigma_1}{\partial r}\right|_{r=1} = 0, \tag{74}$$

$$\left.\frac{\partial \sigma_2}{\partial r}\right|_{r=1} = \frac{1}{3}(1+2\rho)^{1/2}, \tag{75}$$

$$\left.\frac{\partial \sigma_3}{\partial r}\right|_{r=1} = \frac{2}{3}(1-\rho)^{1/2}. \tag{76}$$

Note that in fact σ_2 is the largest singular value, but for notational consistency we won't reorder.

Now we can specify g. Compute

$$\frac{\partial \ell(r)}{\partial r}|_{r=1} = g'\left((1-\rho)^{1/2}\right)\cdot 0 + g'\left((1+2\rho)^{1/2}\right)\frac{1}{3}(1+2\rho)^{1/2} + g'\left((1-\rho)^{1/2}\right)\frac{2}{3}(1-\rho)^{1/2} \tag{77}$$

$$= \frac{1}{3}g'\left((1+2\rho)^{1/2}\right)(1+2\rho)^{1/2} + \frac{2}{3}g'\left((1-\rho)^{1/2}\right)(1-\rho)^{1/2}. \tag{78}$$

Suppose $\frac{\partial \ell(r)}{\partial r}|_{r=1} = 0$. Then

$$\frac{1}{3}g'\left((1+2\rho)^{1/2}\right)(1+2\rho)^{1/2} = -\frac{2}{3}g'\left((1-\rho)^{1/2}\right)(1-\rho)^{1/2}. \tag{79}$$

What is a suitable g? We can rewrite the above constraint as

$$g'\left((1+2\rho)^{1/2}\right) = -2\left(\frac{1-\rho}{1+2\rho}\right)^{1/2} g'\left((1-\rho)^{1/2}\right). \tag{80}$$

Let $\rho = 1/2$. Then

$$g'(\sqrt{2}) = -2\left(\frac{1}{4}\right)^{1/2} g'\left((1/2)^{1/2}\right) \tag{81}$$

$$= -g'(1/\sqrt{2}) \tag{82}$$

However, by assumption, we have $g(t) = g(1/t)$, and so $g'(t) = \frac{1}{t^2}g'(1/t)$. At $t = \sqrt{2}$, $g'(\sqrt{2}) = \frac{1}{2}g'(1/\sqrt{2})$. Thus $\frac{1}{2}g'(1/\sqrt{2}) = -g'(1/\sqrt{2})$ and so $g'(1/\sqrt{2})$ and g is not monotone.

6.2.3 Proof of Proposition 8

In this proof we first show that the penalty $\|\beta\|_{1,2}$ is unchanged by unitary transformation of β.

Proposition 13 *Let $U \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times D}$ be unitary. Then $\|\beta\|_{1,2} = \|\beta U\|$.*

Proof:

$$\|\beta U\|_{1,2} = \sum_{p=1}^{P} \|\beta_{p\cdot} U\| \tag{83}$$

$$= \sum_{p=1}^{P} \|\beta_{p\cdot}\| \tag{84}$$

$$= \|\beta\|_{1,2} \tag{85}$$

□

We then show that this implies that the resultant loss is unchanged by unitary transformation of X.

Proposition 14 *Let $U \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times D}$ be unitary. Then $\widehat{\beta}(UX) = \widehat{\beta}(X)U$.*

Proof:

$$\widehat{\beta}(UX) = \arg\min_{\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta\|_{1,2} \ : \ I_D = UX\beta \tag{86}$$

$$= \arg\min_{\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta\|_{1,2} \ : \ U^{-1}U = U^{-1}UX\beta U \tag{87}$$

$$= \arg\min_{\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta\|_{1,2} \ : \ I_D = X\beta U \tag{88}$$

$$= \arg\min_{\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta U\|_{1,2} \ : \ I_D = X\beta U \tag{89}$$

$$= \arg\min_{\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta\|_{1,2} \ : \ I_D = X\beta. \tag{90}$$

□

6.2.4 Proof of Proposition 9

In this proof we first show that the orthonormal submatrix $X_{\cdot S}$ is contained within the set $\widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(w(X), I_D)$.

Proposition 15 *Let $X_{\cdot S}$ be a rank D orthonormal submatrix of X. Then $S \in S(\beta) : \beta \in \widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(w(X), I_D))$.*

Proof: By Proposition 8 without loss of generality, let $X_{\cdot S} = I_D$. Also, without loss of generality let $S = \{1 \dots D\}$. We show that $\beta = [I_D \ 0]$ satisfies the KKT conditions for $X = [I_D \ X_{-S}]$.

Recall that the KKT conditions for a convex optimization problem are a set of conditions on an element of the domain of the optimization algorithm that, if satisfied, certify that the element is a solution. To write out the KKT conditions, we define the Lagrangian

$$\mathcal{L}(X, \beta, \nu) = \|\beta\|_{1,2} + \nu^T(I_D - w(X)\beta) \tag{91}$$

where $\nu \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times D}$ is the dual variable.

The KKT conditions are then

- Primal feasibility: $w(X)\beta = I_D$
- Stationarity: there exists a dual variable ν such that $0 \in \partial\|\beta\|_{1,2} - w(X)^T\nu$ where ∂ is the subdifferential operator.

where dual feasibility and complementary slackness are ignorable by virtue of the absence of inequality constraints.

First note that in our case, primal feasibility is satisfied by X being rank D and w not effecting the rank of the transformed matrix since it only rescales length and not direction.

For stationarity, recall that

$$\|\beta\|_{1,2} = \sum_{p=1}^{P} \|\beta_{p\cdot}\|_2. \tag{92}$$

Then, by the definition of subdifferential

$$\partial\|\beta\|_{1,2} = \begin{bmatrix} I_D \\ v_{d+1} \\ \dots \\ v_P \end{bmatrix} \tag{93}$$

where $v_p \in \mathbb{R}^D$ can be any vector satisfying $\|v_p\|_2 \leq 1$.

We therefore must show that there exists a ν that satisfies

$$\begin{bmatrix} I_D \\ w(X_{-S})^T \end{bmatrix} \nu = \begin{bmatrix} I_D \\ V_{-S} \end{bmatrix}. \tag{94}$$

At this point we can see that in fact I_D is an appropriate choice of ν since normalization by w leads to vectors satisfying $\|w(X)\|_2 \leq 1$.

Since for this β, $S(\beta) = S$, we have shown that S is the support of a solution to $\beta_{MBP}(w(X), I_D)$. □

The next part of the proof handles the presence of non-unique solutions.

Proposition 16 $S(\widehat{\beta}(X)) = \cup\, S(\beta) \;:\; \beta \in \beta_{MBP}(w(X), I_D)$

Proof: The proposition follows from geometric properties of the solution set. We ignore the case for singleton solutions, for which the proposition is self-evident. Recall that $\widehat{\beta}(X) := \widehat{\beta}^{\ell_2}_{MBP}(w(X), I_D) = \arg\min_{\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{P\times D}} \|\beta\|_F : \beta \in \widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(X, I_D)$. By definition of $\widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(X, I_D)$, $\|\beta_{p.}\|_2 : \beta \in \widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(X, I_D)$ is an affine linear subspace of $\mathbb{R}^P$. The projection of the vector of minimum ℓ_2 distance from the origin to a affine space intersects that space perpendicularly. However, for all $\|\beta_{.p}\|_2$ such that β is on the intersection of this affine space with the coordinate hyperplanes formed by fixing any choices of $\|\beta_{.p}\|_2 = 0$, this vector doesn't intersect this space perpendicularly. Thus, $\widehat{\beta}(X)$ is not on the intersection of the solution polytope $\widehat{\beta}_{MBP}(w(X), I_D)$ with the coordinate hyperplanes. It is therefore maximally non-sparse with respect to any of the minimizing solutions. □

6.2.5 Proof of Proposition 10

X_S admits a QR decomposition $X_S = QR$ where Q is orthogonal and R is upper triangular. By Proposition 8, we can assume without loss of generality that $Q = I_D$. That is, X_S is upper triangular. Thus, $\beta = X_S^{-1}$ is upper triangular with diagonal elements $\beta_{dd} = R^{-1}_{dd}$. $\|\beta_{d.}\|_2 \geq \beta_{dd}$, with equality only occurring when the off-diagonal elements are 0. Therefore, $\|\beta_{1,2}\| \geq D$ with equality occurring only when $\beta = I_D$.

6.2.6 Proof of Proposition 12

Proof: The augmented split Lagrangian minimized by ADMM is

$$\mathcal{L}_{\rho,\gamma,\nu}(X, \beta, z) = \|z\|_{1,2} + \mathrm{tr}(\nu^T(I_D - w(X)\beta)) + \rho\|I_D - w(X)\beta\|_F^2 + \gamma\|\beta - z\|_F^2 \tag{95}$$

This minimization problem is

$$\arg \min_{\beta, z \in P\times D} \mathcal{L}_{\rho,\gamma,\nu}(X, \beta, z) \tag{96}$$

For a more detailed explanation of the reasons to prefer optimizing the split augmented Lagrangian over direct optimization of Equation 31 see Boyd (2010).

The three main subroutines (100 - 104) called by ADMM determine the per iteration complexity. The update rules of the ADMM algorithm used to optimize the augmented split Lagrangian are

$$\beta^{k+1} = \arg \min_{\beta \in P\times D} \mathcal{L}_{\rho,\gamma,\nu}(X, \beta, z^k) \tag{97}$$

$$z^{k+1} = \arg \min_{z \in P\times D} \mathcal{L}_{\rho,\gamma,\nu}(X, \beta^{k+1}, z) \tag{98}$$

$$\nu^{k+1} = \nu^k + \rho(I_D - w(X)\beta^{k+1}) \tag{99}$$

We will analyze the computational complexity of each of these steps by rewriting the update rules according to the specifics of the isometry pursuit problem.

The beta update Equation 100 projects the solution onto the feasible set.

$$\beta^{k+1} = \arg \min_{\beta \in P\times D} \mathrm{tr}({\nu^k}^T(I_D - w(X)\beta)) + \rho\|I_D - w(X)\beta\|_2^2 + \gamma\|\beta - z^k\|_2^2 \tag{100}$$

$$= (\rho\, w(X)^T w(X) + \gamma I_D)^{-1}(\rho\, w(X)^T I_D + \gamma z^k + w(X)^T \nu^k) \tag{101}$$

The computational complexity of this computation is dominated by the inverse - that is, $O(D^2P)$.

Subsequently, the z update Equation 102 is soft-thresholding operation onto a contracted level set $\|\|\|_{1,2}$ ball.

$$z^{k+1} = \arg\min_{z \in P \times D} \|z\|_{1,2} + \gamma \|z - \beta^{k+1}\|_2^2 \tag{102}$$

$$= \begin{cases} (1 - \frac{1}{\gamma \|\beta_{j\cdot}^{k+1}\|_2})(\beta_{j\cdot}^{k+1}) \text{ if } \|\beta_{j\cdot}^{k+1}\|_2 > \frac{1}{\gamma} \\ 0 \text{ otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{103}$$

The computational complexity of this operation is $O(PD)$.

Finally, the ν update Equation 104 increases the squeezing of the z and β variables towards to each other.

$$\nu^{k+1} = \nu^k + \rho(I_D - w(X)\beta^{k+1}) \tag{104}$$

In this step, the dual variable ν that controls the penalty accrued by the splitting is updated in the direction of the constraint violation. The computational complexity of this operation is dominated by that of the matrix multiplication $w(X)\beta^{k+1}$. That is, it is $O(D^2P)$. □

6.3 Partial derivatives of candidate losses

We summarize the column-wise derivatives of the losses in Table 2. Throughout this section let $X = [x_1, \ldots, x_D] \in \mathbb{R}^{D \times D}$ be full rank. For a scalar loss $L(X)$, write

$$\nabla_X L = \left[\frac{\partial L}{\partial x_1}, \ldots, \frac{\partial L}{\partial x_D} \right]. \tag{105}$$

All formulas are stated on smooth strata: rank deficient matrices, repeated singular values, and zero rows of pseudoinverse factors should be handled using subgradients.

We will use two common identities. First, if $X = U \operatorname{diag}(\sigma) V^\top$ is a singular value decomposition and $L(X) = \sum_{d=1}^{D} \phi(\sigma_d(X))$, then

$$\nabla_X L = U \operatorname{diag}(\phi'(\sigma_1), \ldots, \phi'(\sigma_D)) V^\top. \tag{106}$$

Second, for normalized losses let $N = n_q^{\times D}(X)$. If $M = \nabla_N L$, then the column-wise chain rule is

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial x_p} = \mathrm{D} n_q(x_p)^\top M_{\cdot p}. \tag{107}$$

For $r = \|x\|_2$, write $n_q(x) = s(r)x$ with $s(r) = q(r)/r$. Then

$$\mathrm{D} n_q(x) = s(r) I_D + \frac{s'(r)}{r} x x^\top, \tag{108}$$

$$s'(r) = \frac{q'(r)}{r} - \frac{q(r)}{r^2}, \tag{109}$$

$$q'(r) = -\frac{2e(e^r - r^{-2} e^{1/r})}{(e^r + e^{1/r})^2}. \tag{110}$$

Since $\mathrm{D} n_q(x)$ is symmetric, the transpose in this chain rule may be omitted.

Distortion. Let $\sigma_1 = \sigma_{\max}(X)$ and $\sigma_D = \sigma_{\min}(X)$ with corresponding singular vectors u_1, v_1 and u_D, v_D. For

$$L_{\mathrm{dist}}(X) = \frac{\sigma_1}{\sigma_D} - 1, \tag{111}$$

The spectral gradient identity gives

$$\nabla_X L_{\mathrm{dist}} = \frac{u_1 v_1^\top}{\sigma_D} - \frac{\sigma_1}{\sigma_D^2} u_D v_D^\top. \tag{112}$$

The derivative is insensitive to uniform rescaling, which is the sense in which this loss does not prefer unit length.

Isometry loss. For

$$L_{\text{iso}}(X) = \sum_{d=1}^{D} g(\sigma_d(X)) - D, \tag{113}$$

we have

$$g'(t) = \frac{e^t - t^{-2}e^{1/t}}{2e}. \tag{114}$$

Thus

$$\nabla_X L_{\text{iso}} = U \operatorname{diag}(g'(\sigma_1), \ldots, g'(\sigma_D))V^\top. \tag{115}$$

S-divergence to identity. Let $G = X^\top X$ and

$$L_{\text{sdiv}}(X) = \log\det\left(\frac{G + I_D}{2}\right) - \frac{1}{2}\log\det(G). \tag{116}$$

The constant $\log\det(1/2)$ does not contribute to the derivative. Using $d\log\det A = \operatorname{tr}(A^{-1}dA)$ and $dG = dX^\top X + X^\top dX$,

$$\nabla_X L_{\text{sdiv}} = 2X(G + I_D)^{-1} - XG^{-1}. \tag{117}$$

Normalized log-det volume. Let $N = n_q^{\times D}(X)$ and

$$L_{\text{nld}}(X) = -\sum_{d=1}^{D} \log \sigma_d(N). \tag{118}$$

For square full-rank N, this is $-\log|\det N|$, so

$$\nabla_N L_{\text{nld}} = -N^{-\top}. \tag{119}$$

Therefore, by the column-wise chain rule,

$$\frac{\partial L_{\text{nld}}}{\partial x_p} = -\mathrm{D}n_q(x_p)^\top (N^{-\top})_{\cdot p}. \tag{120}$$

Frobenius pseudoinverse. Let $N = n_q^{\times D}(X)$ and $B = N^{-1}$. For

$$L_{\text{frob}}(X) = \|N^{-1}\|_F - \sqrt{D}, \tag{121}$$

the differential identity $dB = -B(dN)B$ gives

$$\nabla_N L_{\text{frob}} = -\frac{N^{-\top}N^{-1}N^{-\top}}{\|N^{-1}\|_F}. \tag{122}$$

Thus

$$\frac{\partial L_{\text{frob}}}{\partial x_p} = \mathrm{D}n_q(x_p)^\top \left(-\frac{N^{-\top}N^{-1}N^{-\top}}{\|N^{-1}\|_F}\right)_{\cdot p}. \tag{123}$$

Isometry pursuit proxy. Let $N = n_q^{\times D}(X)$ and $B = N^{-1}$. The differentiable proxy for the IsometryPursuit table row is

$$L_{\text{ip}}(X) = \|N^{-1}\|_{1,2} - D. \tag{124}$$

Define $R \in \mathbb{R}^{D\times D}$ by

$$R_{p\cdot} = \frac{B_{p\cdot}}{\|B_{p\cdot}\|_2}. \tag{125}$$

Then $R \in \partial\|B\|_{1,2}$ on the smooth stratum where every row of B is nonzero, and

$$\nabla_N L_{\text{ip}} = -B^\top R B^\top. \tag{126}$$

The column-wise gradient is therefore

$$\frac{\partial L_{\text{ip}}}{\partial x_p} = \mathrm{D}n_q(x_p)^\top (-B^\top R B^\top)_{\cdot p}. \tag{127}$$

6.4 Support cardinalities

Figure 5 plots the distribution of $|\widehat{S}_{IP}|$ from Table 3 in order to contextualize the reported means. While typically $|\widehat{S}_{IP}| << P$, there are cases for Ethanol where this is not the case that drive up the means. Further investigation into the extreme failure of isometry pursuit to sparsify in the the minor chunk of the bimodal Ethanol support cardinality distribution is warranted.

6.5 Timing

While wall-time of algorithms is a non-theoretical quantity that depends on implementation details, it provides valuable context for practitioners. We therefore report the following runtimes on a 2021 Macbook Pro. The particularly high variance for brute force search in the second step of TwoStageIsometryPursuit is likely due to the large cardinalities reported in Figure 5.

Name	IP	2nd stage	Greedy
Iris	1.24 ± 0.02	0.00 ± 0.00	0.02 ± 0.00
Wine	2.32 ± 0.17	0.13 ± 0.12	0.03 ± 0.00
Ethanol	8.38 ± 0.57	0.55 ± 1.08	0.07 ± 0.01

Table 4: Algorithm runtimes in seconds across replicates.

Example 2

$$X_S = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{1}{2} & \frac{-1}{2} & \frac{1}{2} & \frac{-1}{2} & \frac{1}{2} & \frac{-1}{2} \\ \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & 0 & 0 & & \\ 0 & 0 & \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 00 & 0 & \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} & \end{bmatrix}. \tag{128}$$

Proof: Let

By Given the symmetry of the second and third columns around the y axis, the loss will not change regardless of whether we upweight one or downweight the other, these changes necessarily being in conjunction. We therefore assume that their loadings with respect to the second column of the target matrix (the D dimensional identity) are the same. Clearly, they will both then have value of $\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}$. The question then becomes, what should the values of the first column in the loading matrix β be?

We can answer this question with a simple differential equation. Let b denote the constraint violation $1 - X_{1.}\beta_{.1}$.

Then

$$\frac{\partial b}{\partial \beta_{11}} = \frac{\partial b}{\partial \beta_{21}} \tag{129}$$

$$= \frac{1}{2} \tag{130}$$

On the other hand, due to the value of $\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}$ already assumed for the second loading of the second and third features,

$$\frac{\partial l}{\partial \beta_{11}} = \frac{\partial l}{\partial \beta_{21}} \tag{131}$$

$$= \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\sqrt{\frac{1}{3} + x^2} \tag{132}$$

$$= \frac{1}{2}(\frac{1}{3} + x^2)^{-\frac{1}{2}}(2x) \tag{133}$$

$$= \frac{x}{\sqrt{\frac{1}{3} + x^2}}. \tag{134}$$

This means that the tradeoff

$$\frac{\partial l}{\partial b} = \frac{1}{2x}\sqrt{\frac{1}{3} + x^2}. \tag{135}$$

In contrast, $\frac{\partial l}{\partial \beta_{11}} = 1$ and similarly for its constraint violation. Solving for the equilibrium, we get

$$\frac{1}{2x}\sqrt{\frac{1}{3} + x^2} = 1 \tag{136}$$

$$\frac{1}{3} + x^2 = 4x^2 \tag{137}$$

$$\frac{1}{3} = 3x^2 \tag{138}$$

$$x = \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}. \tag{139}$$

This leads to a value for l of

$$\sqrt{\frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{9}} + \sqrt{\frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{9}} + \frac{2}{3} \tag{140}$$

$$= \sqrt{\frac{4}{9}} + \sqrt{\frac{4}{9}} + \frac{2}{3} \tag{141}$$

$$= \frac{2}{3} + \frac{2}{3} + \frac{2}{3} \tag{142}$$

□

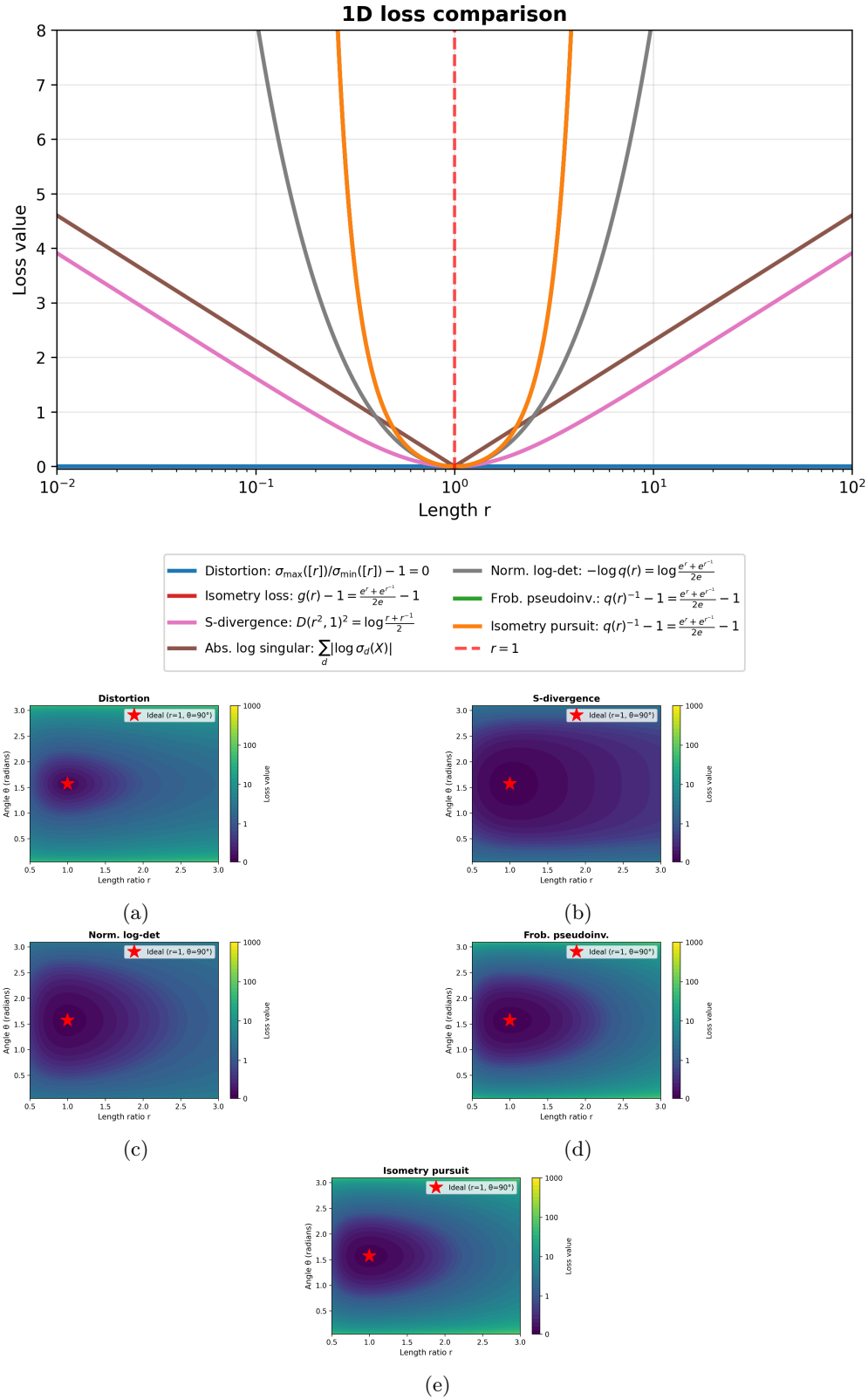
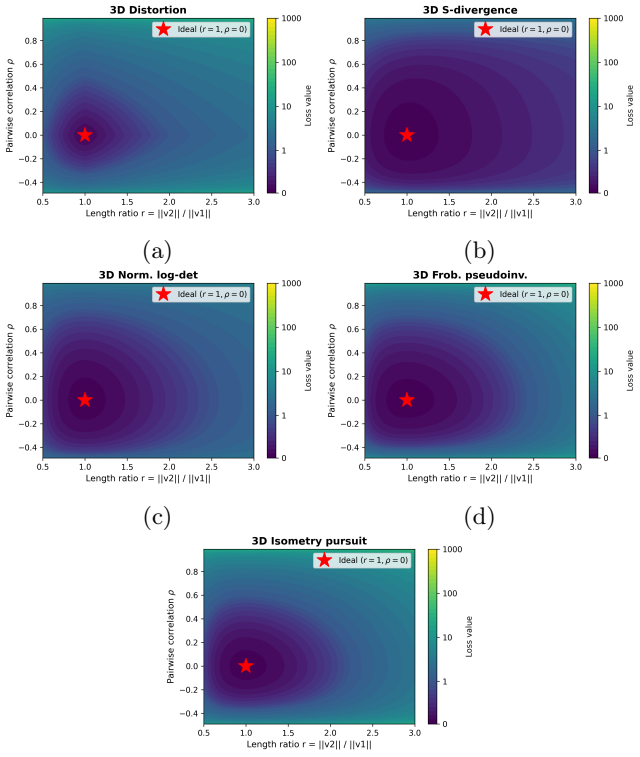


Figure 2: Comprehensive loss function comparison for isometry pursuit. Top: 1D loss curves for $X = [[r]]$ showing loss behavior versus vector length. Bottom: 2D loss landscapes for 2×2 matrices parametrized by length ratio r and angle θ with shared colorbars. S-divergence is shown as the representative generic spectral loss. Red vertical dashed line in the 1D plot marks $r = 1$ (optimal). Red star in each 2D plot marks $(r = 1, \theta = \pi/2)$ (ideal). The panels visualize whether each candidate loss prefers unit-length and orthogonal structure at the ideal point. See Table 2 for mathematical definitions.



(a) (b) (c) (d) (e)

Figure 3: Loss function comparison for 3D equicorrelated matrices, shown as two-dimensional landscapes. Each matrix consists of three vectors in $\mathbb{R}^3$ with lengths $(1, r, 1)$ and common pairwise correlation ρ. The horizontal axis varies the length ratio $r = \|v_2\|_2/\|v_1\|_2$, while the vertical axis varies ρ. S-divergence is shown as the representative generic spectral loss. The red star marks the ideal orthonormal setting $(r, \rho) = (1, 0)$.

Figure 4: Difference in isometry losses $\ell(\widehat{S}_g) - \ell(\widehat{S}_{TSIP})$ for Wine, Iris, and Ethanol datasets. The distributions reflect the relative losses of the supports estimated by greedy optimization on the ℓ objective is less than or equal to ℓ loss of the support estimated by TwoStageIsometryPursuit. As shown here and detailed in Table 3, losses are generally lower for two-stage isometry pursuit solutions.

../figures/wine_cardinalities.png ../figures/iris_cardinalities.png ../figures/ethanol_cardinalities.png

(a) Wine (b) Iris (c) Ethanol

Figure 5: Support cardinalities for each dataset after IsometryPursuit.